

ISYS3438: Case Study Brief – People, Performance and Social Sustainability

Context

Southern Cross Services Australia is a large people-intensive organisation with operations across Melbourne, Sydney, Brisbane, and Adelaide, serving a broad mix of corporate, community, and government-linked clients. The organisation has experienced strong workforce growth over the past several years, with most recruitment concentrated at the Melbourne headquarters and smaller but important branch operations in New South Wales, Queensland, and South Australia. While the organisation presents itself as values-driven and socially responsible, internal workforce data suggests a more complicated picture. Senior leadership has asked for a data-informed review of workforce capability, inclusion, retention, and employee experience because a number of people-related indicators appear to be moving in different directions at the same time. Naturally, management wants clarity after creating the mess.

At a headline level, the organisation appears stable: it has a large active workforce, a substantial graduate and postgraduate talent base, and clear investment in recruitment. However, beneath that surface are several strategic tensions. Gender representation is uneven across the organisation, and while women are strongly represented in some high-performing and high-satisfaction segments, the overall workforce remains male-dominated. There are also visible salary gaps between men and women in comparable job groups, raising questions about pay equity, progression pathways, and whether high-performing women are being rewarded consistently. These issues are especially important because the organisation claims to support fairness, inclusion, and sustainable employment practices.

A second concern is retention. Terminations are high enough to affect workforce continuity, operating cost, and service delivery. Termination patterns vary by gender, performance, and job group, and the reasons for exit suggest that not all turnover is voluntary or strategically healthy. Leadership is concerned that some parts of the workforce may be carrying higher risk of disengagement, lower wellbeing, weaker development support, or inconsistent access to flexible work.

The organisation is also trying to connect its workforce strategy to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially goals linked to decent work, gender equality, reduced inequalities, good health and wellbeing, and quality education. For this case, the SDG Score should be interpreted as a composite workforce sustainability indicator rather than a direct measure of all 17 SDGs. It is intended to show how well the organisation is performing on people-related sustainability factors such as inclusion, fairness, development, wellbeing, retention risk, and employee experience. In other words, students should treat the SDG Score as a business-facing proxy for social sustainability performance. It is not an external ESG rating and should not be read that way.

Leadership wants a visual and evidence-based story that explains where the workforce is performing well, where inequities or structural issues exist, and what actions should be prioritised to improve job satisfaction, Indigenous recruitment and inclusion, workforce sustainability, and overall business performance.

Your Task

You have been engaged as a data visualisation and workforce analytics team to review the dataset and prepare a management-ready dashboard and short presentation for the executive group. Your job is not just to describe the data, but to identify meaningful organisational problems, explain their likely drivers, and support practical recommendations with clear visual evidence. The goal is to move from charts to decisions, which is somehow still not standard practice in many organisations.

Your analysis should focus on four connected themes: workforce composition, employee experience, equity and inclusion, and organisational sustainability. Start by profiling the workforce. Show where employees are located, how the workforce is distributed by gender, age, education, employment status, and active versus terminated employees, and where recruitment is concentrated. Then examine employee experience by exploring job satisfaction, performance, development, wellbeing, and related people metrics. Look for patterns by gender, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander identification, education level, job role, and location.

You should specifically test whether there are visible inequities in salary outcomes between men and women in similar positions, and whether these differences remain visible across education levels and performance bands. You should also investigate who is most likely to score highly on performance, satisfaction, and SDG Score, and whether these outcomes align with the organisation's stated commitment to inclusion and sustainable employment. Pay close attention to the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander workforce cohort: assess representation, gender balance within that group, their satisfaction and SDG outcomes, and whether the recruitment pattern appears meaningful or merely symbolic.

The SDG Score should be analysed as a composite internal sustainability metric. Students should explain what it represents, show how it relates to job satisfaction, performance, retention, and inclusion, and discuss whether stronger social sustainability outcomes appear linked to better business outcomes. A good submission will not treat SDG as a decorative extra column. It should use it to test whether workforce practices aligned with fairness, wellbeing, and development also correspond with stronger employee outcomes.

Your final output should include a dashboard and a concise set of recommendations. Recommendations should be specific, prioritised, and evidence-based. They may address pay equity, Indigenous recruitment and support, retention interventions, talent development, flexible work, or executive reporting metrics. The strongest work will show not only what is happening, but why it matters and what leadership should do next.

What the dataset contains

The workbook contains one employee-level table plus summary and notes sheets. The employee table includes demographics, location, education, tenure, salary components, job satisfaction, performance, termination status and a social sustainability measure labelled **SDG Score**.

Field group	Key fields	Why it matters
Workforce profile	Gender, ATSI identification, age, education, office location	Supports equity, inclusion and workforce composition analysis
Work experience	Years at company, current role tenure, manager tenure, training, flexible work, absence	Helps explain satisfaction, performance and attrition
Outcomes	Job satisfaction, performance rating, SDG score, termination status and reason	These are the main management questions
Rewards	Base salary, oncosts, super	Enables pay-gap and total-remuneration analysis

How to interpret SDG Score

Do not treat SDG Score as a literal measure of the 17 United Nations SDGs. In this dataset it is a workforce-level proxy for social sustainability. It is designed to help us connect people metrics to broader responsible business outcomes.

SDG Score is coded on a 1 to 5 scale and is calculated as:

SDG Score = round($0.35 \times \text{Inclusion Index} + 0.25 \times \text{Wellbeing Index} + 0.20 \times \text{Development Index} + 0.20 \times \text{Job Satisfaction}$)

Interpretation. Higher SDG scores suggest a stronger internal social sustainability environment: employees feel more included, report better wellbeing, receive stronger development support, and are more satisfied at work. In a real organisation this type of index could be linked to SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-Being), SDG 5 (Gender Equality), SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities) and SDG 17 (Partnerships and institutional capability).

Business issues that should be visible in the dashboard

Issue	What may be visible	Why executives care
Gender pay gap within similar roles	Male salaries are generally higher than female salaries in comparable roles and levels	Signals equity risk, reputational risk and possible inefficiency in reward design
Performance concentration among women	Ratings 4 and 5 are disproportionately female	Could indicate a strong female talent cohort, uneven opportunity structures, or rating bias
ATSI recruitment and outcomes	ATSI representation is stronger than the national private-sector average and high SDG or satisfaction scores cluster heavily in this group	Raises questions about which inclusion practices work, and whether those practices are scalable
High termination rate with uneven gender pattern	Terminations sit at roughly 23% and skew female, with reasons varying across groups	May suggest pressure points in retention, manager support, flexibility or career design
Location effects	Melbourne HQ dominates headcount and may shape organisation-wide averages	Branch-level experience may be masked by HQ volume



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